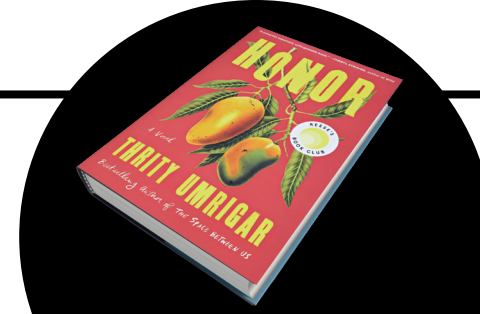
Indianness, with the Love Commandos profiting off them," she says. "Arif-Monika and Reshma-Preethi's stories illustrate other themes about India that were relevant in the moment, like right-wing Hindu nationalism."

As Choksi traced their new lives, she realised that the "pursuit of love and its aftermath was ultimately a kind of displacement". All three couples faced the fundamental conflict of going against the grain of who they believed they were: "They're not exactly the rebellious kind ... So, even as they perform this subversive act, there is a huge part of them that longs for the peace of not having performed that act."

The Newlyweds is also a sobering reminder of how 'progress' or progressiveness doesn't necessarily translate into emancipation for the less privileged. For instance, when Section 377 was struck down by the Supreme Court and Choksi called Reshma to share the news, they had no clue and were instead consumed by worries of Preethi cheating on them. "I thought that was so telling of how little and often, how much the political affects the personal, especially for people on the margins," says Choksi.

Over half a decade, Choksi took hundreds of hours of interviews, supplementing the research with court records, FIRs, official documents and forensic results gathered from courthouses across the country. The biggest challenge, though, was to portray the couples in a way that showcased the breadth of their personalities. "Because I spent so much time with them... I wanted to showcase how the virtuosity of that big triumphant emotion, love, fizzles out into the hum of daily life. And that even if love came at these huge costs, somewhere in their heart, they all believe it was worth it." ■

Shikha Kumar



HONOR
by Thrity Umrigar
SWIFT PRESS
₹629 (KINDLE);
337 pages

A Bride and Prejudice

Thrity Umrigar's harrowing new novel reminds us of how death does us part and love brings us close

How far can you go for love? What sacrifices can you make at its altar? These are some of the questions Thrity Umrigar stretches to the extreme in her latest novel, *Honor*.

Smita Agarwal, an Indian-American journalist, is forced to cut short her holiday in the Maldives to cover a story in India for the American newspaper she is employed at. She returns to her country of birth, 20 years after she and her family had to leave, under desperate circumstances. Past wounds now reopen and cut deep.

At the heart of Agarwal's investigation is Meena Mustafa, a young Hindu woman whose brothers burn her Muslim husband to death in Birwad, a village on the Gujarat-Maharashtra border. In trying to save him, Mustafa loses parts of herself. What's left are a "face that makes babies cry", "the hands of a cripple", one good eye and a mother-in-law who never stops blaming her for her son's death. Shunned by both Hindus and Muslims, she sees herself as the "dog who belongs neither in the house nor on the streets". The only thing that keeps her going is her baby, a reminder of her loving husband who had been "the only sun in her sky".

On the recommendation of a lawyer, Mustafa sues her brothers. This is the beginning of her long battle for justice. As journalist and victim start getting attached, India, too, emerges as a strong, full-bodied and utterly complex character. It simmers under the fuels of religious fundamentalism, casual and calamitous misogyny, caste and class divisions. But Umrigar, like Agarwal, is a seasoned journalist. No matter how horrific the crimes and betrayals in the book, the author steers clear from passing judgements. She unmasks evil individuals as outcomes of unequal and ruthless systems.

THRITY UMRIGAR unmasks evil individuals as outcomes of ruthless systems

Umrigar explores the harm caused unwittingly by well-meaning people who take up cudgels for the less fortunate and view their lives through the prism of their own. She also dwells on the concept of power and the laughable absurdity of it: a powerful person in one situation can be rendered hopelessly powerless in another. But if there is plenty of shunning and othering, there is also an abundance of care and solicitude. If unimaginable violence exists, so does tenderness.

Sometimes, though, the prose takes a sentimental and didactic turn, the author's voice indistinguishable from those of her characters. The generous sprinkling of conversation fillers like *'achchha'*, *'yaar'*, *'na'* in dialogue impairs the reading experience, and recurrent patois used for certain characters grates.

But overall, the novel is compelling and makes you sit up in terror as it resonates all too well with the India we inhabit. Eventually, however, *Honor* is a delicate portrait of love as it softens people who are baked within hardened boundaries of hate and prejudice. As a character says: "This is what it meant to care so much about another human being that you were willing to sacrifice everything, even pride and self-respect." ■

Sukhada Tatke